

Mountain wildlife

The steep crags and valleys of the Himalayas provide many refuges for wildlife. Forests on the lower slopes give way to high altitude meadows and snowfields. Animals of the higher slopes, such as the yak, are adapted to survive the winters; others migrate to warmer, lower slopes.



Himalayan griffon

The Himalayan griffon is a large, aggressive vulture that soars over some of the highest mountain slopes in search of food. The diet of vultures is almost entirely restricted to carrion. The Himalayan griffon's powerful hooked bill is strong enough to rip open the leathery hide of a dead yak to feast on the entrails.

Hooked beak helps pull apart prey.



Rhododendron

When in flower, rhododendrons set the mountainside ablaze with a riot of colour. Their tiny seeds are readily spread by wind or water.



Yak

Domesticated for centuries, the yak is still found living wild in some parts of its mountain range. With its long, shaggy coat, a yak can survive temperatures as low as -40°C (-40°F). It grazes on whatever plants are available, including mosses and lichens, and can use snow as a source of water.



Sharp spines on head and neck provide protection.



Armoured pricklenape agama

This lizard lives in the treetops in mountain forests. Its greenish-brown scales conceal it among twigs and leaves. Pricklenape agamas have sharp claws that give them a sure grip, as they run and leap through the branches.

Long toes and claws grip when climbing.

Northern bat

In summer, this hardy bat forages for insects in the forest and even up into the Arctic Circle. To survive the winter it hibernates in caves or buildings. Its distribution is dictated by the availability of suitable roost sites.



Fur for warmth

Boreal forest wildlife

Just south of the Arctic tundra is a vast forest of conifer trees. In Asia, this boreal forest is called the taiga. Wildflowers, and animals such as the sable, are adapted to exploit the brief summers and withstand the long, harsh winters.



Sable

The sable hunts all year round for nestlings and rodents. It also eats shoots and berries if prey is scarce. The sable sleeps, shelters, and gives birth in hollow logs or tree holes.

Thick fur covers the whole body and even the soles of the feet.



Norway spruce

Narrow-crowned spruces are a characteristic feature of the taiga. Snow slides easily from their curved branches without breaking them. Norway spruce grows at the western reaches of the taiga, soon giving way to Siberian spruce. The seeds of both trees provide food for birds and rodents.



Great grey owl

To find enough food, including voles, lemmings, and other small rodents, the great grey owl hunts by day as well as night. It may travel far to a good source of food, but returns to the dense boreal forest to breed. It chooses a secure nest site in a tree, or may use another large bird's old nest.



Desert wildlife

Not all deserts are hot all year round. Temperate deserts, such as the Gobi in Central Asia, have scorching hot summers, but icy cold winters. Nights are cold even in summer, as there is no vegetation to trap the heat. To survive here, animals must be adapted both to the dry environment and extremes of temperature.



Onager

Onagers live in small herds in the desert. There is little vegetation here for grazing animals, but the onager can cope with eating tough desert grasses and straw. Wolves, although uncommon, are their main predators. To defend themselves, onagers can run fast for long distances.

Almost all-round vision helps them to spot danger.

Pale fur for camouflage in desert



Mongolian gerbil

Like many small desert animals, these gerbils escape from temperature extremes by digging underground burrows. Living below ground also helps to conserve bodily moisture. Gerbils nibble roots, shoots, seeds, and buds, and drink water if it is available.

In a drought, they can get sufficient moisture from the early morning dew on their food.

Cheek pouches stretch so gerbil can carry food in its mouth.



Bactrian camel

Few of these desert creatures remain in the wild. A Bactrian camel has a very thick woolly coat to protect it from severe cold in winter. Fat stored in two humps on its back enables it to survive with little food or water for long periods of time.



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